

Week 2 Logic Test

The Case of the Two-Faced Word

A Whately Puzzle on Terms, Ambiguity, and Equivocation

Name: _____

Date: _____

Whately's warning: Before asking whether a conclusion follows, ask whether the important words keep the same meaning. An argument may look strong only because one term has been allowed to carry two ideas at once. Fix the term; then test the reasoning.

The Puzzle Story

At the Academy of Straight Thinking, an old cabinet stands in the corner of the library. Inside it rests the **Golden Key**, the prize given to the student who can unlock a confused argument.

On the cabinet door is written:

“The Golden Key belongs to the student who can prove that the rule is just.”

Beneath the words are three folded notices from the old Head Tutor. Each notice contains a trap: one word turns its face in the middle of the argument.

The Notice of the Fair Judge says:

“The trial was fair. But the sky was not fair that day, for it rained. Therefore the trial was not fair.”

The Notice of the Free Hall says:

“All students should have free speech in the Hall. Therefore no one should ever have to pay for a speech in the Hall.”

The Notice of the True Heir says:

“Only the true heir may open the cabinet. Nora spoke truly about the cabinet. Therefore Nora is the true heir.”

Three students hurry forward. Mira points to the Fair Judge notice. Elias points to the Free Hall notice. Nora points to the True Heir notice. Each claims that the notice proves the answer.

The Head Tutor has left one final sentence:

“Do not ask first who sounds clever. Ask first whether the word stayed faithful to one meaning.”

Part I: Find the Two-Faced Word

For each notice, identify the term that changes meaning. Then decide whether the conclusion follows once the term is fixed.

1. The Notice of the Fair Judge

Argument: “The trial was fair. But the sky was not fair that day, for it rained. Therefore the trial was not fair.” **Two-faced word:**

Meaning in the first use:

Meaning in the second use:

Is this ambiguity or equivocation? Explain.

Once the word is fixed, does the conclusion follow? Why or why not?

2. The Notice of the Free Hall

Argument: “All students should have free speech in the Hall. Therefore no one should ever have to pay for a speech in the Hall.” **Two-faced word:**

Meaning in the first use:

Meaning in the second use:

Is this ambiguity or equivocation? Explain.

Once the word is fixed, does the conclusion follow? Why or why not?

3. The Notice of the True Heir

Argument: “Only the true heir may open the cabinet. Nora spoke truly about the cabinet. Therefore Nora is the true heir.” **Two-faced word:**

Meaning in the first use:

Meaning in the second use:

Is this ambiguity or equivocation? Explain.

Once the word is fixed, does the conclusion follow? Why or why not?

Part II: Fix the Term

Choose one notice from Part I. Rewrite the argument so that the key term is used in only one clear sense. Then test the repaired argument.

Notice chosen: _____

Fixed meaning of the key term:

Rewritten argument:

Does the rewritten argument prove its conclusion? If not, what hidden assumption or missing fact remains?

Part III: Review from Week 1

Use the Week 1 four-step test on this new claim:

“The Head Tutor wrote the rule in gold ink, so the rule must be wise.”

Conclusion:

Stated reason:

Hidden assumption:

Does the conclusion follow? Explain briefly.

Part IV: What Can Logic Decide?

Mark each item as **Logic can test this** or **Logic alone cannot decide this**. Then explain two choices.

1. Whether the word *fair* is being used in two senses. _____
2. Whether the old Head Tutor was morally wise. _____
3. Whether the conclusion follows after *free* is fixed to one meaning. _____
4. Whether Nora actually has a legal right to the cabinet. _____
5. Whether a hidden assumption is needed for the argument to work. _____

Explain two choices:

Part V: Macbeth Bridge

Macbeth hears the witches say that “none of woman born” shall harm him. He treats the phrase as if it means, “No human being can harm me.”

1. What meaning does Macbeth assume?

2. What other meaning does the phrase allow?

3. What hidden assumption does Macbeth make about the phrase?

4. Why is this a dangerous equivocation rather than a simple falsehood?

Final Whately Claim

In one sentence, explain why a thinker must fix the meaning of key terms before deciding whether an argument follows.
